
The Opta-stat-packification of football: Why are the game's milestones getting weirder?

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Back in October, after a 2-0 home win for Manchester United over Sunderland heralded one of the final false micro-dawns of the Ruben Amorim era, a beautifully benign piece of information was posted on X, which read:

Ruben Amorim becomes the first Manchester United manager since Sir Alex Ferguson to win his 50th game at the club.

It had all the cadence and vocabulary of a modern-day football stat and, at first glance, looked like it could be a reasonable milestone. But no, Ruben Amorim had become the first Manchester United manager since Sir Alex Ferguson to win his 50th game at the club. *Specifically the 50th*. What conclusion were we supposed to draw from this?

The answer, almost certainly, was nothing: this “stat”, like so many others on a typical matchday, was destined to be buried by the news cycle and never cited again.

The marriage of football reporting with surface-level data has, in the most part, been a fruitful one. Straightforward metrics can be easily editorialised to capture the fortunes of teams and players: the minutes since a goalkeeper's net was last breached, the hours since a hapless striker last scored, the days since an injury-plagued former wonderkid last kicked a ball.

Then again, after Liverpool shared the points with Manchester City in November 2023, Sky Sports produced a live TV graphic confirming that man of the match Trent Alexander-Arnold had ranked “joint-first for goals scored” in a 1-1 draw.



Alexander-Arnold was joint-top dog away to Manchester City in November 2023 (Shaun Botterill/Getty Images)

To paraphrase the anti-VAR mantra, then: data itself isn't the problem, it's often the people using it. And in the expanding universe of football content, there's a lot of data and a lot of people.

Supplying that data to those people is Opta, the sports analytics company which has a near-monopoly on football stats distribution in the UK media. And while advanced metrics ([your PPDAs](#), [your field tilts](#), [your xGOTs](#)) are slowly taking hold and being used responsibly, the most surface-level data sets (goals, ages, minutes) remain the lubricant for much of the output of mainstream football outlets.

It isn't much of a betrayal of industry omerta to reveal that Opta's stat packs, issued to paying media outlets before a Premier League weekend and after each individual game, are the unsung heroes of football match reporting. They detail — to varying degrees of tenuousness but with an occasional statistical nugget of gold — a series of streaks, firsts and barren runs: a team's best stretch of consecutive away wins since 1977, the first Brazilian in the Premier League to do this, the first top-flight side to fail to do that. Win, lose or draw, there will always be something in there to prop up the prevailing consensus about how a team are broadly performing.

And, honestly, the labyrinths that can be constructed from this basic information...

What was the icing on the cake here? That it was specifically *two* seasons in a row, or that two other West Ham players had already achieved this never-before-considered feat before Lucas Paqueta

did? Either way, some dull, statistical water had been turned into briefly diverting wine.

Filling the content void is not the only impulse here, though. Amid the blizzard of narrative-adjacent stat curation is a palpable addiction to milestones, thanks in large part to the two-decade goalscoring torrents of Cristiano Ronaldo and Lionel Messi. Milestone purists had only just come to terms with numbers outside of 50, 100, 250, 500 and 1,000 being given dubious gravitas, when the whole thing was blown apart even further by transfer reporter Fabrizio Romano.

Ronaldo and Messi's shattering of various goalscoring barriers in the latter part of their careers has intensified as a result of some selective convenience, in the hope of unearthing yet another landmark figure: league goals only, continental competitions only, internationals, open-play goals, goals scored after turning 30... there's always a round number on the way somehow. Indeed, Messi recently reached [the quasi-milestone of 900 goals](#). An astounding total, let's face it — so why wait for the thousandth?

Opta's ability to consult simultaneous variables and conjure up a real-time, mid-game stat — before disseminating it to media outlets for them to relay to their audiences — has led to some frankly exceptional logical gymnastics. The more layers you see in a stat, the more unsure you are how impressed you're supposed to be.

Against FC Copenhagen in January, Barcelona's Marcus Rashford finally achieved what his critics said he never would, and "became the second Englishman to score direct free kicks for two different Champions League teams after David Beckham".

A few weeks later, Juventus defender Lloyd Kelly suffered the ignominy of being "the second Englishman to receive a red card in a UEFA Champions League knockout stage match for a non-English team, after Matt Derbyshire for Olympiacos versus Bordeaux in the 2009-10 round of 16". And despite nobody ever, ever considering those elements together before in the history of football, I felt immediately compelled to defend this stat's right to exist.

That news came as the nation was still reeling from Arsenal's Eberechi Eze becoming "the first player in 10 years to assist two goals in an FA Cup game at the Emirates" against Wigan Athletic (please note that this just happened to occur against Wigan, they weren't part of the stat, mercifully). And just days ago, Sky Sports confirmed that we were all lucky enough to be alive to witness "the first goalless draw between Nottingham Forest and Fulham this century [surprised face emoji]."

My concept of a landmark had long become blurred beyond recognition, each stat containing just the right number of caveats to render them almost meaningless, yet somehow drawing me in.

A year ago, tweeted Squawka, Chemsdine Talbi (19 years and, crucially, 285 days old) became the youngest (right, OK, I'm listening) Belgian player (hmm, OK) in Champions League history (ooh, that's big) to score a brace (a brace!).

(Talbi has since declared his international allegiance to Morocco, presumably at the cost of his baby-faced Belgian brace-bagger title reverting to... whoever held it previously.)



Chemsidine Talbi fresh from making Champions League history last season... (Isabella Bonotto/Getty Images)

Occasionally, though, this juggling of innocuous variables can — seemingly accidentally — result in something quite impressive-sounding.

After last summer's Club World Cup final, it emerged from Opta's algorithm that Cole Palmer was only (only? Did this qualify for an "only?") the third player to score multiple goals in a final against Paris Saint-Germain, joining Michel Platini for Saint-Etienne in the 1982 Coupe de France and Alessandro Del Piero for Juventus in the second leg of the UEFA Super Cup in February 1997.

This stat had poise. An exclusive club had been suddenly formed. One that wouldn't quite have the same lustre if it had included, say, Christian Stumpf for Rapid Vienna in the 1996 Cup Winners' Cup final.

But there are some who happily exist in the cosy, knowingly niche corners of football data.

The X account of El Data Tricolor, which dedicates itself to Colombian football, noted in October that Luis Suarez's penalty for Sporting CP against Napoli in the Champions League meant he now occupied top spot in the prestigious ranking of... Colombian players who have scored past the tallest goalkeepers in the Champions League (Napoli's Vanja Milinkovic-Savic just edging out Fraser Forster and Thibaut Courtois by one and two centimetres respectively.) Now, we could pause to ponder how and why those data sets collided in the first place, let alone how it became an ongoing concern, but you can't help but admire such acts of statistical spelunking.

And if you're struggling to place a football stat in the appropriate, helpful context, there's fun to be had in going rogue.

"You could fill every upstairs seat of a London double-decker bus (a Routemaster) with permanent managers of Nottingham Forest or Watford since 2011," confirmed The Times' stats man Bill Edgar, the bracketed clarification perhaps the crowning glory. Edgar thrives in a conscious niche, one which enjoys a freedom granted by the fact that a football stat doesn't necessarily need to underline an achievement or a failure, it can just be the aligning of some happily unnecessary planets:

Edgar's main rival for single-eyebrow-raising stat hits is *The Athletic's* very own Duncan Alexander, who — when not calculating that James Milner has played in 1.3 per cent of English top-flight games since September 1888 — has capitalised on 1) unfettered access to the Opta database and 2) an unnatural fixation with pop-culture chronology:

Ronaldo and Messi continue to edge themselves closer to a genuine landmark, perhaps football's ultimate for an individual player.

Before then, we may at least be able to satisfy our single-serving stats hunger around the middle of January 2027, by which point Michael Carrick could become only the second Manchester United manager since Peter Mutharika was elected for a second term as president of Malawi to win their 50th game in charge.

Remember where you were.

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